

Chapter 7 — From a Kingdom to an Empire

The Mauryas and Ashoka

The one-line point: Magadha becomes **India's first empire** under the Mauryas — and then its greatest king, having won the bloodiest war of his life, **publicly announces he was wrong to fight it** and carves that confession into rock across the subcontinent. **The Lion Capital on your passport comes from here.**

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Syllabus Classification

Field	Value
Subject	History → Ancient India
Sub-discipline	Early Historic — Imperial Period (India's first pan-subcontinental empire)
Period	321 BCE – 185 BCE
Prelims (GS Paper I)	<i>History of India</i> → Mauryan administration, Ashokan edicts, sources
Mains (GS Paper I)	★★★★ <i>Indian culture</i> : Mauryan art (pillars, capitals, Barabar caves, stupas) — a favourite; also governance and Ashoka's dhamma
Also feeds	Art & Culture ★★★★★ (Lion Capital, polished pillars, Barabar caves), Polity ★ (State Emblem, national symbols; welfare-state ideas), Ethics (GS4) ★★ (Ashoka as a case study in remorse, moral leadership, tolerance), Governance (administration, public works), IR (Ashoka's missions as early cultural diplomacy)
Weightage	★★★★★★ — very high. Ashokan edicts and Mauryan art are repeat performers
Overlaps with	Ch.5 (Magadha's rise), Ch.6 (Buddhism), Ch.10 (Mauryan art and architecture)

 **Ancient India → Imperial.** But for Mains, its home is **Art & Culture** (Mauryan pillars) and **Ethics** (Ashoka's transformation). The Lion Capital connects it to **Polity** via the State Emblem.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this chapter you should be able to:

- ☐ **Name and evaluate** the sources for Mauryan history: *Arthashastra*, *Indica*, *Mudrarakshasa*, Buddhist/Jaina texts, and — most importantly — **the edicts**.
- ☐ **Sequence** the Mauryan rulers and state each one's key achievement.
- ☐ **Describe** the Mauryan administrative structure: capital, provinces, provincial capitals, officials, *dhamma mahamatta*.
- ☐ **Explain** why the empire was governed **unevenly** — and why that matters.
- ☐ **Narrate** the **Kalinga war** and quote its consequence from **Major Rock Edict XIII**.
- ☐ **Define Ashoka's dhamma** precisely — and explain why it is **not** simply Buddhism.

- ☐ **List** the specific measures Ashoka took to propagate dhamma.
- ☐ **Classify** the edicts: Major/Minor Rock Edicts, Pillar Edicts, Cave inscriptions — with key locations.
- ☐ **State** the languages and scripts of the edicts, including the bilingual Greek–Aramaic ones.
- ☐ **Explain** how the edicts were **deciphered** and by whom.
- ☐ **Describe** the **Sarnath Lion Capital** and its relationship to the **State Emblem of India**.
- ☐ **Assess** the causes of Mauryan decline.
- ☐ **Evaluate** Ashoka as a ruler — the case for and against.



Start Here: The Most Extraordinary Thing Any King Ever Did

Every empire in history announces its victories. Rock Edict XIII announces something else entirely:

"When he had been consecrated eight years, the Beloved of the Gods, the king Piyadassi, conquered Kalinga. A hundred and fifty thousand people were deported, a hundred thousand were killed and many times that number perished. Afterwards, now that Kalinga was annexed, the Beloved of the Gods very earnestly practised Dhamma, desired Dhamma, and taught Dhamma. On conquering Kalinga the Beloved of the Gods felt remorse, for, when an independent country is conquered, the slaughter, death, and deportation of the people is extremely grievous to the Beloved of the Gods, and weighs heavily on his mind..."

Read that again, and notice what is happening.

WHAT EVERY OTHER ANCIENT KING CARVED IN STONE:

"I conquered. I destroyed. I am glorious. Fear me."

WHAT ASHOKA CARVED IN STONE:

"I conquered. I counted the dead. I WAS WRONG.
I will not do it again. Here is what I will do instead."

...and then he PUBLISHED IT across his entire empire,
IN THE LANGUAGES HIS SUBJECTS SPOKE, permanently, in rock.



H. G. Wells's often-quoted line: *"Amidst the tens of thousands of names of monarchs that crowd the columns of history... the name of Ashoka shines, and shines almost alone, a star."* **Keep this for an Ethics or Essay answer** — but pair it with the critical view further down, because uncritical hagiography is weaker than balanced assessment.



What Ashoka actually built is a public, immutable, distributed, multilingual communication layer for state policy. Content authored once at the centre, replicated to ~40 locations across the subcontinent, **localised into the local script and language**, engraved on the most durable medium available, and sited deliberately at high-traffic nodes — trade routes, pilgrimage centres, river crossings. **It is state communication designed for permanence, reach and comprehension.** Two thousand three hundred years later, we are still reading the deployment.

1 Sources — Where Mauryan History Comes From

Chapter 1's lesson pays off here: this is the first Indian empire where we have **abundant and varied** sources.

Source	Author	Value	⚠ Caution
ASHOKAN EDICTS ★ ★ ★	Ashoka himself	The gold standard. Contemporary, unaltered, in the king's own voice. Our single best source	They are royal propaganda — they say what Ashoka <i>wanted</i> known. Absence of a topic ≠ absence of the thing
ARTHASHASTRA ★ ★ ★	Kautilya / Chanakya / Vishnugupta	A detailed treatise on statecraft, economy, law, espionage, diplomacy (<i>saptanga</i> theory, <i>mandala</i> theory)	⚠ It is a prescriptive manual of how a state <i>should</i> work , not a description of the Maurya state. Its date is debated (later recensions exist). Do not treat it as a Mauryan census
INDICA ★ ★	Megasthenes , Seleucus Nikator's ambassador at Chandragupta's court	Eyewitness account of Pataliputra, the army, the administration, society	⚠ Survives only in fragments quoted by later Greek writers (Arrian, Strabo, Diodorus). Contains clear errors — e.g. his claim that Indian society had seven castes (not four), and that there was no slavery
MUDRARAKSHASA ★	Vishakhadatta	Sanskrit play on Chandragupta's rise and Chanakya's stratagems	Written ~700 years later. Literary, not historical
Buddhist texts	<i>Dipavamsa</i> , <i>Mahavamsa</i> (Sri Lankan chronicles), <i>Divyavadana</i> , <i>Ashokavadana</i>	Ashoka's Buddhism, the Third Council, Mahinda's mission	Devotional; they portray Ashoka as an ideal Buddhist king
Jaina texts	<i>Parishishtaparvan</i>	Chandragupta's Jainism and his end at Shravanabelagola	Sectarian
Puranas	—	Dynastic lists and regnal years	Later compilation
Archaeology	Pataliputra excavations (Kumrahar), NBPW pottery, punch-marked coins	Material confirmation	—

🎯 **The Arthashastra caveat is genuinely important and separates good answers from average ones.** Students routinely write "Mauryan administration had X because the *Arthashastra* says so." **Correct framing:** "*The Arthashastra, though prescriptive and of debated date, describes an elaborate bureaucratic apparatus which likely reflects Mauryan practice in broad outline.*" That hedge is worth marks.

2 The Rulers

THE MAURYAN DYNASTY, 321–185 BCE

321 BCE

- CHANDRAGUPTA MAURYA (r. c. 321–297 BCE)
- Overthrew DHANA NANDA with CHANAKYA's help
 - Defeated SELEUCUS NIKATOR (c.305 BCE) – gained Kabul, Kandahar, Herat, Baluchistan; gave 500 elephants; a marriage alliance followed
 - MEGASTHENES came to his court
 - Tradition: became a JAIN, abdicated, went with BHADRABAHU to SHRAVANABELAGOLA, died by *sallekhana*



297 BCE

- BINDUSARA (r. c. 297–273 BCE)
- Greek sources call him "AMITROCHATES" (Sanskrit AMITRAGHATA = "slayer of foes")
 - Extended control into the DECCAN
 - Patronised the AJIVIKAS
 - Deimachus was ambassador at his court



268 BCE

- ASHOKA (r. c. 268–232 BCE)
- Titles in the edicts: DEVANAMPIYA ("Beloved of the Gods") and PIYADASSI ("Pleasant to behold")
 - KALINGA WAR – 261 BCE (8th regnal year)
 - Adopted and propagated DHAMMA
 - Convened the THIRD Buddhist Council (Pataliputra)
 - Sent missions abroad – MAHINDA & SANGHAMITTA to SRI LANKA
 - The EMPIRE AT ITS GREATEST EXTENT



WEAK SUCCESSORS – Dasharatha (gave Barabar caves to the Ajivikas), Samprati, Shalishuka, ...
BRIHADRATHA – the last Maurya, ASSASSINATED in 185 BCE by his own commander-in-chief
PUSHYAMITRA SHUNGA → the SHUNGA dynasty begins

185 BCE

Chandragupta Maurya — the founder

Fact	Detail
Came to power	c. 321 BCE , overthrowing Dhana Nanda of Magadha, guided by Chanakya (Kautilya/Vishnugupta)
Extent	From Afghanistan to Bengal, and south into the Deccan — the first genuinely subcontinental Indian empire
Seleucus Nikator ★	Alexander's general; defeated by Chandragupta around 305 BCE . Treaty: Seleucus ceded Kabul (Paropanisadae), Kandahar (Arachosia), Herat (Aria) and Baluchistan (Gedrosia); Chandragupta gave 500 war elephants
Megasthenes ★	Seleucus's ambassador; wrote <i>Indica</i>
His end ★	Jaina tradition: he abdicated, embraced Jainism, accompanied Bhadrabahu south to Shravanabelagola (Karnataka) , and died by <i>sallekhana</i> (Ch.6 link)

🎯 **The Seleucus episode deserves emphasis:** an Indian ruler defeated one of Alexander's own generals and **gained territory in modern Afghanistan**. That's a significant, concrete fact and a corrective to the notion that Alexander's campaign left India subordinate.

3 Administering an Empire — And Why It Was Uneven

NCERT's central analytical point in this chapter: the empire was NOT governed uniformly. This is a genuinely sophisticated idea for a Class 6 book, and UPSC likes it.

THREE ZONES OF MAURYAN CONTROL – decreasing tightness

ZONE 1: THE CAPITAL REGION – PATALIPUTRA and around DIRECT, TIGHT CONTROL

- Ruled directly by the king and his ministers
- Full bureaucracy: tax collection, judiciary, spies, army

ZONE 2: THE PROVINCES – 4 (or 5) provincial capitals GOVERNED BY ROYAL PRINCES (KUMARAS)

- * TAXILA (north-west)
- * UJJAIN (west) – Ashoka was governor here as a prince
- * SUVARNAGIRI (south – "golden mountain," near gold mines)
- * TOSALI (east – in Kalinga, after the conquest)
- (* Kalinga/Samapa sometimes counted separately)

- Local customs and laws often continued
- Central control was real but looser

ZONE 3: OUTLYING & FOREST AREAS LOOSE / INDIRECT CONTROL

- The empire mainly wanted RESOURCES: timber, elephants, honey, wax, precious stones – and safe passage along ROADS
- ATAVIKA (forest) peoples were largely left alone, but WARNED (Rock Edict XIII explicitly tells forest tribes to reform or face consequences – a rare hard edge in Ashoka's rhetoric)
- Control was concentrated along ROADS and RIVERS, not spread evenly over territory

 This is not a uniformly provisioned system — it's a core with tightly-managed nodes, a middle tier of delegated regional control, and an edge where you only maintain the routes and extract the resources you need. The map looks like a solid block; the actual control was a **network of corridors and hubs**, not an area. **Say this in a Mains answer and it reads as genuine understanding rather than memorised extent.**

Officials and machinery

Office	Function
Mantri Parishad	Council of ministers
Kumara / Aryaputra ★	Royal princes as provincial governors
Mahamatta / Mahamatra ★	High officers with varied duties
DHAMMA MAHAMATTA ★★ ★	A new office created by Ashoka — officers to teach, propagate and supervise <i>dhamma</i> , look after the welfare of women, prisoners, the aged, and various sects
Rajuka ★	Officers in charge of rural administration and justice; Ashoka gave them independence in judicial matters (Pillar Edict IV)
Yukta	Subordinate revenue officials
Pradeshika	District-level officers; conducted quinquennial tours (every 5 years)
Samaharta / Sannidhata	Chief revenue collector / treasurer (<i>Arthashastra</i>)
Nagaraka	City administrator
Adhyaksha	Superintendents of departments
Gupta-charas / Spies ★	An extensive espionage network (<i>Arthashastra</i>)

Megasthenes on Pataliputra ★: he describes a city on the Ganga, ~**9 miles long and 1.5 miles wide**, surrounded by a **wooden palisade with 570 towers and 64 gates**, and a deep moat. He describes a **municipal committee of 30 members in 6 boards of 5**, handling crafts, foreigners, births/deaths, trade, manufactured goods, and sales tax. He also describes a **war office of 30 in 6 boards** (infantry, cavalry, elephants, chariots, navy, transport). (*Archaeology at Kumrahar has confirmed wooden palisade remains.*)

The army: Pliny, citing Megasthenes, gives Chandragupta **600,000 infantry, 30,000 cavalry, 9,000 elephants**. Treat these numbers as impressive but not precise.

Roads: the **Uttarapatha** ran from the north-west to Pataliputra and on to Tamralipti — the ancestor of the Grand Trunk Road. Ashoka claims to have planted **banyan trees for shade**, dug **wells**, built **rest-houses (dharmashalas)** and planted **medicinal herbs** along the roads.

4 ✂ The Kalinga War (261 BCE) — The Turning Point

Element	Detail
When	c. 261 BCE , in Ashoka's 8th regnal year
Where	Kalinga — modern coastal Odisha
Why	Kalinga controlled the eastern coastal trade route to South India and Southeast Asia, and had remained independent. It was strategically and commercially valuable
The cost ★★	By Ashoka's own account in Rock Edict XIII : 100,000 killed, 150,000 deported, and "many times that number perished"
The result ★	Remorse (anusochana) — and a public renunciation of war as an instrument of policy
Where it's recorded ★★	Major Rock Edict XIII

★ The detail that historians find most telling: **Rock Edict XIII — the Kalinga edict — is deliberately NOT inscribed in Kalinga itself.** In Kalinga, two **Separate Rock Edicts** were installed instead (at **Dhauli** and **Jaugada**), addressed to the officials there and concerned with the just and humane treatment of the newly conquered people ("*All men are my children*").

Why? Almost certainly because publishing a triumphal casualty count in the conquered province would have inflamed it. **Ashoka's communication was audience-aware — he varied the message by region.** That's a genuinely sharp observation and a strong point for a Mains answer.

After Kalinga: "*Bherighosha*" (the sound of the war drum) was replaced by "*Dhammaghosha*" (the sound of dhamma) — a phrase worth quoting.

⚠️ **A necessary critical note:** Ashoka **did not dismantle the empire, disband the army, or restore Kalinga's independence.** He renounced *further* conquest. He also retained capital punishment (though he granted a three-day respite to the condemned) and issued warnings to the forest peoples. **A balanced Mains answer states both the sincerity of the transformation and its limits.** That balance scores better than either uncritical praise or cynicism.

5 🌀 Ashoka's DHAMMA — Be Precise Here

The single most misunderstood topic in this chapter.

⚠️ **Dhamma (Prakrit for Sanskrit *dharma*) was NOT Buddhism.** Ashoka was personally a Buddhist, but the *dhamma* he propagated through the edicts was a **broad, non-sectarian code of ethical and social conduct** intended for **all his subjects, of every faith**. The edicts do **not** mention the Four Noble Truths, the Eightfold Path, nirvana, or ask anyone to become Buddhist.

What dhamma actually asked of people

Principle	In practice
Respect for elders	Obedience to parents, teachers and elders
Respect for brahmanas and shramanas ★	Note: BOTH — the orthodox priesthood <i>and</i> the heterodox renunciants
Kindness to servants and slaves	Humane treatment of dependants
Ahimsa / non-injury to living beings	Restrictions on animal slaughter; Ashoka reduced killing in the royal kitchen
TOLERANCE of all sects ★★	Rock Edict XII — the great edict on religious tolerance
Generosity (<i>dana</i>)	Giving to shramanas, brahmanas, the poor
Truthfulness, purity, gentleness	Personal virtue
Little sin, many good deeds	The general formula

★ ★ **Major Rock Edict XII deserves to be known almost verbatim** — it is one of the earliest state declarations of religious tolerance anywhere in the world:

*"One should not honour only one's own sect and condemn the sects of others... **He who honours his own sect and condemns the sects of others** wholly from devotion to his own sect... **injures his own sect very severely**. Concord alone is commendable... let all listen and be willing to listen to the doctrines professed by others."*

Note the *argument*, not just the sentiment: **sectarian aggression harms your own sect**. It is a reasoned case for tolerance, not merely a pious wish. **This is prime GS4 Ethics and Essay material** — quote it for answers on secularism, tolerance, pluralism and communal harmony.

How Ashoka propagated dhamma

1. **INSCRIPTIONS** ★ — carved on rocks and pillars across the empire, **in local languages and scripts**
2. **DHAMMA MAHAMATTAS** ★ ★ — a **new cadre of officers** created specifically to spread dhamma and oversee welfare
3. **DHAMMA YATRAS** ★ — the king replaced royal pleasure tours (*vihara yatras*, i.e. hunting) with **tours to meet people, teach dhamma and give gifts**
4. **Public works** — wells, rest houses, shade trees, **medical treatment for humans AND animals** (Rock Edict II mentions medicinal herbs and treatment provided even beyond his borders, in the Chola, Pandya, Satiyaputra, Keralaputra and Tamraparni territories, and in Antiochus's realm) ★
5. **Missions abroad** ★ — Rock Edict XIII names five Hellenistic kings to whom he sent envoys: **Antiochus II (Syria), Ptolemy II (Egypt), Antigonus (Macedon), Magas (Cyrene), Alexander (Epirus)**; missions also went to **Sri Lanka (Mahinda and Sanghamitta — his son and daughter), Suvarnabhumi (Southeast Asia), Kashmir, Gandhara**
6. **Restricted animal sacrifice and festive gatherings (samajas)** involving killing
7. **Third Buddhist Council** at Pataliputra under **Moggaliputta Tissa**

🌐 **Rock Edict XIII is remarkable as a diplomatic document too** — it names contemporary Greek kings by name, which is how historians **anchor Mauryan chronology to the well-dated Hellenistic world**. Without those five names, our dating of Ashoka would be far shakier. **A beautiful example of Chapter 1's cross-source dating in action.**

6 🗿 The Edicts — Classification, Languages, Decipherment

Classification

Type	Number	Where	Content
MAJOR ROCK EDICTS ★	14	On large boulders at ~8–10 sites	The core dhamma programme
MINOR ROCK EDICTS	Several	~15+ sites	Ashoka's personal commitment to Buddhism; the only ones naming him "ASHOKA" ★
MAJOR PILLAR EDICTS ★	7	On polished sandstone pillars	Later in his reign; review of dhamma policy
MINOR PILLAR EDICTS	—	Sarnath, Sanchi, Allahabad, Rummindei, Nigalisagar	Schism edicts; commemorative
CAVE INSCRIPTIONS ★	—	Barabar caves (Bihar)	Donated to the AJIVIKAS ★
SEPARATE ROCK EDICTS ★	2	Dhauli and Jaugada (Kalinga)	Instructions on humane administration of the conquered

Key sites

Site	Location	Note
Girnar ★	Junagadh, Gujarat	Major Rock Edicts. Same rock also bears the later Rudradaman and Skandagupta inscriptions about the Sudarshana lake ★
Dhauli ★	Odisha	Separate Rock Edicts; famous rock-cut ELEPHANT sculpture
Jaugada	Odisha	Separate Rock Edicts
Kalsi	Uttarakhand	Major Rock Edicts
Shahbazgarhi & Mansehra ★	Pakistan (NW)	Major Rock Edicts — in KHAROSHTHI script ★
Sopara	Maharashtra	Major Rock Edicts
Yerragudi	Andhra Pradesh	Major + Minor Rock Edicts
Maski, Gujjarra, Nettur, Udegolam ★	Karnataka / MP	Minor Rock Edicts that name "ASHOKA" directly ★
Kandahar ★ ★	Afghanistan	Bilingual GREEK–ARAMAIC inscription
Sarnath ★ ★ ★	UP	The LION CAPITAL pillar; schism edict
Sanchi	MP	Pillar; schism edict
Rummindei (Lumbini) ★	Nepal	Pillar recording Ashoka's visit; tax on the village reduced to 1/8 ★
Nigalisagar	Nepal	Pillar; enlargement of the stupa of Buddha Konakamana
Topra & Meerut	Delhi	Pillars moved to Delhi by Firoz Shah Tughlaq in the 14th century ★
Allahabad-Kosam	UP	Pillar bearing Ashoka's edicts and Samudragupta's later prashasti (Ch.9) ★
Lauriya-Nandangarh, Lauriya-Araraj, Rampurva	Bihar	Pillars with animal capitals
Barabar caves ★	Bihar	Donated to the Ajivikas ; earliest rock-cut caves in India ; mirror-polished interiors

Languages and scripts ★★

Script	Where	Direction
BRAHMI ★	Most of the subcontinent	Left to right. The ancestor of nearly all Indian scripts (Devanagari, Tamil, Bengali, Telugu, Kannada, and also Tibetan, Thai, Burmese)
KHAROSHTHI ★	North-west (Shahbazgarhi, Mansehra)	RIGHT to LEFT (derived from Aramaic)
GREEK ★	Kandahar, Afghanistan	—
ARAMAIC ★	Kandahar, Taxila, Laghman	—

Language: overwhelmingly **PRAKRIT** (the spoken vernacular), *not* Sanskrit — the same accessibility principle you saw with the Buddha in Chapter 6.

★ **The Kandahar bilingual (Greek + Aramaic) is a superb detail.** In a region where people spoke Greek and Aramaic, Ashoka **localised his message into their languages**. That is deliberate, audience-aware statecraft — and it also proves the reach of Mauryan authority into Afghanistan.

🔒 Decipherment — the Chapter 1 payoff

By the medieval period **nobody could read Brahmi**. Firoz Shah Tughlaq moved two Ashokan pillars to Delhi in the 14th century and had scholars try — none could.

Step	Detail
Deciphered by ★★	JAMES PRINSEP , in 1837 — an official of the East India Company's mint in Calcutta and secretary of the Asiatic Society
How	He worked from short donative inscriptions on Sanchi's railings, many ending in the same two characters — correctly guessed to be " <i>danam</i> " (gift) — and worked outward
The twist ★	Prinsep could now read the edicts, but they were issued by a king calling himself " Devanampiya Piyadassi " — a name matching no known king. It was only later, when Minor Rock Edicts at Maski (1915) , and subsequently Gujarra, Nettur and Udegolam , were found naming " Ashoka " directly , that the identification was confirmed against the Sri Lankan chronicles

🎯 **Two facts here get asked constantly: James Prinsep, 1837; and Maski as the edict that names Ashoka.** Also note the elegance of the story — **one man's decipherment recovered an entire emperor whom Indian tradition had almost forgotten**. Ashoka's reputation in modern India is, in a real sense, a 19th-century archaeological recovery.

7 🦁 Mauryan Art — Ch.10 Preview, But Learn It Here

Mauryan art is a Mains favourite. Do not skip this.

The pillars

Feature	Detail
Material	Chunar sandstone (from near Varanasi) — quarried at one place and transported hundreds of kilometres ★
Height	Typically 12–15 m ; weight ~50 tonnes
Structure	MONOLITHIC — shaft carved from a single stone ★; separate capital on top
The polish ★★	A brilliant, glass-like " Mauryan polish " — a surface finish whose technique remains not fully understood and which was not replicated in later periods
Parts	Shaft (plain, tapering) → Inverted lotus/bell capital → Abacus (drum with animal/floral reliefs) → Crowning animal (lion, bull, elephant, horse)

🦁 The Sarnath Lion Capital — know it in detail

1 FOUR LIONS, back to back, facing the four directions (only 3 visible from any angle)
→ symbolising the Buddha's teaching radiating in all directions; also royal power

2 Originally surmounted by a large 32-spoked DHARMACHAKRA (wheel) — now lost

3 ABACUS: a circular drum bearing four animals separated by four 24-spoked wheels —
LION (north) · ELEPHANT (east) ·
HORSE (south) · BULL (west)

4 INVERTED LOTUS (bell) base

ADOPTED AS THE STATE EMBLEM OF INDIA — 26 January 1950

- Only THREE lions are visible in the emblem (the 4th is hidden)
- The DHARMACHAKRA of the abacus appears at the centre
- Below it: SATYAMEVA JAYATE from the MUNDAKA UPANISHAD (Ch.6 link!)
- The 24-spoked wheel is the ASHOKA CHAKRA on the NATIONAL FLAG

★★ This is a three-way crossover — History (Ch.7) → Art & Culture (Ch.10) → Polity (national symbols). Know: the capital is at the **Sarnath Museum**; the emblem was adopted **26 January 1950**; only **three lions** are visible; the motto comes from the **Mundaka Upanishad**; and the **Ashoka Chakra** on the flag is the 24-spoked wheel from the abacus.

Other capitals: the **Rampurva Bull**, the **Lauriya-Nandangarh Lion**, the **Sankissa Elephant**, the **Rampurva Lion**.

🕒 The Barabar Caves ★

- Near Gaya, Bihar. **The earliest surviving rock-cut caves in India**
- Excavated under **Ashoka** and his grandson **Dasharatha**, and donated to the **Ajivikas** (Ch.6 link)
- Famous for the **mirror-like Mauryan polish** on the interior granite walls
- **Lomas Rishi** cave has a facade imitating a **wooden thatched hut** in stone — showing the transition from wooden to stone architecture ★
- (Also the "Marabar Caves" of E. M. Forster's A Passage to India.)

 **Ashoka, a Buddhist, donated caves to the Ajivikas.** That single fact is the strongest material evidence of the tolerance he preached in Rock Edict XII. **Use it as your example when asked to show that Ashoka's tolerance was practised, not merely proclaimed.**

Also Mauryan: the **Didarganj Yakshi** (a polished chauri-bearer statue from Patna — though its date is debated between Mauryan and later), and the original brick core of the **Sanchi Stupa**, which Ashoka built (later enlarged by the Shungas → Ch.10).

8 Decline of the Mauryan Empire

Ashoka died c. **232 BCE**; the empire ended in **185 BCE** — barely **50 years** later. Why so fast?

Cause	Argument	Assessment
1. Weak successors ★	No ruler of comparable ability after Ashoka; the empire was reportedly partitioned among heirs	Strong — a highly centralised system depends on a capable centre
2. Over-centralisation ★	Everything depended on the king personally; there was no institutional continuity independent of him	Strong. The system had a single point of failure
3. Vast size, slow communication	Managing Afghanistan to Bengal with pre-modern communications was inherently fragile	Strong
4. Financial strain	An enormous army and bureaucracy, plus lavish donations to sects and extensive public works, strained the treasury	Plausible
5. Ashoka's pacifism ★	(H. P. Sastri's view) The renunciation of war weakened the army's edge	⚠ Contested. Ashoka never disbanded the army; the empire held for decades after him. Present it as a view, not a fact
6. Brahmanical reaction ★	(H. P. Sastri) Ashoka's ban on sacrifice and support for heterodoxy antagonised brahmanas; Pushyamitra Shunga , who killed the last Maurya, was himself a brahmana who revived the Ashvamedha	Debated. Ashoka's edicts explicitly enjoin respect for brahmanas, which cuts against a simple anti-brahmanical reading
7. Provincial oppression ★	Ashoka's own edicts record revolts at Taxila (which he was sent to quell as a prince) caused by misrule by officials	Well-evidenced from the edicts themselves
8. Foreign invasions	Bactrian Greeks pressing the north-west after Ashoka	Contributory
9. Economic factors (D. D. Kosambi)	Currency debasement and fiscal pressure	Debated

The end: in **185 BCE**, the last Maurya, **Brihadratha**, was **assassinated during a military review by his own commander-in-chief, Pushyamitra Shunga**, who founded the **Shunga dynasty**.

 **The best framing for a Mains answer:** *"The Mauryan empire's rapid collapse reflects the structural fragility of a highly centralised, personality-dependent polity rather than any single cause; the absence of institutional mechanisms capable of surviving a weak monarch proved decisive."* **Then** add the debated factors with attribution.

Assessing Ashoka — The Balanced View

Because uncritical praise reads as unsophisticated, here is both sides.

✓ The case for	⚠ The case for caution
Publicly acknowledged the horror of his own war — unprecedented in ancient kingship	He kept Kalinga; he did not restore its independence
Institutionalised welfare: hospitals, wells, roads, shade trees, veterinary care	Retained capital punishment (with a three-day respite)
Rock Edict XII — a reasoned, early state doctrine of religious tolerance	Warned forest peoples of consequences in RE XIII — coercion remained available
Practised tolerance materially — Barabar caves to the Ajivikas	The edicts are his own account ; we lack an independent check
Localised his message into subjects' languages and scripts	Dhamma may also have served as an integrative ideology for a diverse empire — pragmatic as well as moral
Sent missions that carried Buddhism across Asia — a lasting civilisational effect	The empire collapsed within 50 years of his death

🎯 **The mature conclusion:** *"Ashoka's dhamma was simultaneously a genuine ethical commitment and an instrument of imperial integration; the two readings are not mutually exclusive, and the evidence supports both."* **That sentence will serve you in any Ashoka question.**

Prelims

Topic	The exact thing to know
Sources ★★	<i>Arthashastra</i> (Kautilya , prescriptive), <i>Indica</i> (Megasthenes , fragments), <i>Mudrarakshasa</i> (Vishakhadatta), edicts (best)
Chandragupta ★	321 BCE; defeated Seleucus Nikator ; gained Afghan territories; 500 elephants ; Jain end at Shravanabelagola
Bindusara ★	Greek " Amitrochates "; patronised Ajivikas
Ashoka's titles ★★	Devanampiya ("Beloved of the Gods"), Piyadassi ("Pleasant to behold")
Kalinga war ★★	261 BCE , 8th regnal year; 100,000 killed, 150,000 deported ; recorded in Major Rock Edict XIII
RE XIII not in Kalinga ★	Separate Rock Edicts at Dhuli and Jaugada instead
RE XII ★★	Religious tolerance
RE II	Medical treatment for humans and animals, including in foreign realms
Dhamma ≠ Buddhism ★★	A broad ethical code for all subjects
Dhamma mahamatta ★★	New officers created by Ashoka
Provinces ★★	Taxila, Ujjain, Suvarnagiri, Tosali — governed by kumaras
Rajukas	Rural administration + judicial independence (Pillar Edict IV)
Scripts ★★	Brahmi (most), Kharoshthi (NW, right-to-left), Greek & Aramaic (Kandahar)
Language	Prakrit , not Sanskrit
Decipherment ★★	James Prinsep, 1837
Edict naming "Ashoka" ★★	Maski (also Gujarra, Nettur, Udegolam)
Barabar caves ★★	Donated to the AJIVIKAS ; earliest rock-cut caves; Lomas Rishi facade
Lion Capital ★★	Sarnath ; four lions, 24-spoked wheels, abacus animals (lion/elephant/horse/bull); State Emblem, 26 Jan 1950 ; only three lions visible ; <i>Satyameva Jayate</i> from the Mundaka Upanishad
Mauryan polish ★	Distinctive, unreplicated; Chunar sandstone ; monolithic shafts
Missions abroad ★	Mahinda & Sanghamitta to Sri Lanka ; five Hellenistic kings named in RE XIII
Third Buddhist Council ★	Pataliputra , under Moggaliputta Tissa
Rummindei pillar ★	Lumbini; tax reduced to 1/8
Pillars moved to Delhi	By Firoz Shah Tughlaq (Topra, Meerut)
End of the dynasty ★	Brihadratha killed by Pushyamitra Shunga, 185 BCE

Traps:

- "Ashoka's dhamma was Buddhism" → **FALSE**. Non-sectarian ethical code
- "Ashoka's edicts are in Sanskrit" → **FALSE**. **Prakrit** (plus Greek/Aramaic at Kandahar)
- "All Ashokan edicts are in Brahmi" → **FALSE**. Kharoshthi in the north-west; Greek and Aramaic at Kandahar

- "The edicts name him as Ashoka" → **Mostly FALSE**. They use **Devanampiya Piyadassi**; only the **Minor Rock Edicts at Maski, Gujjarra, Nettur and Udegolam** name Ashoka
- "Rock Edict XIII was inscribed in Kalinga" → **FALSE**. It is **omitted** there
- "Ashoka abolished capital punishment" → **FALSE**. He granted a **three-day respite**
- "The Barabar caves were given to Buddhists" → **FALSE**. To the **AJIVIKAS**
- "Chandragupta was defeated by Seleucus" → **FALSE**. The reverse

Mains

- **Art & Culture** ★ ★ ★ : "Discuss the salient features of Mauryan art and architecture." → pillars, monolithic shafts, Mauryan polish, Chunar sandstone, Lion Capital, Barabar caves, Lomas Rishi facade, Sanchi's original stupa; distinguish **court art** (pillars, palaces) from **popular art** (yaksha/yakshi figures, pottery)
 - **Ethics (GS4)** ★ ★ : Ashoka as a case study in **remorse, moral courage, accountability of power, and religious tolerance**. Quote **RE XII** and **RE XIII**
 - **Governance**: the welfare state in ancient India — public works, veterinary care, *dhamma mahamattas*, judicial independence for *rajukas*
 - **Polity**: national symbols and their sources
 - **Decline**: structural fragility of over-centralised polities
-

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Devanampiya	"Beloved of the Gods" — Ashoka's title
Piyadassi	"Pleasant to behold" — Ashoka's title
Dhamma	Prakrit for <i>dharma</i> ; Ashoka's non-sectarian ethical code
Dhamma mahamatta	Officer appointed to propagate dhamma and oversee welfare
Dhamma yatra	Ashoka's tours to meet people and teach dhamma
Kumara / Aryaputra	Royal prince serving as provincial governor
Rajuka	Officer of rural administration and justice
Pradeshika	District officer conducting five-yearly tours
Yukta	Subordinate revenue official
Nagaraka	City administrator
Atavika	Forest peoples/regions
Arthashastra	Kautilya's treatise on statecraft
Indica	Megasthenes's account of India
Brahmi	The script of most Ashokan edicts; ancestor of Indian scripts
Kharoshthi	Right-to-left script of the north-west
Chunar sandstone	Stone used for the Mauryan pillars
Mauryan polish	The distinctive mirror-like surface finish
Monolithic	Carved from a single stone
Dharmachakra	Wheel of the law
Sallekhana	Jain ritual fasting to death (Chandragupta's end)
Uttarapatha	The great northern trade route
Sudarshana lake	Reservoir at Girnar built under the Mauryas, repaired by Rudradaman and Skandagupta

2-MINUTE RECAP

1. **Chandragupta Maurya, 321 BCE**, overthrew the Nandas with **Chanakya's** help; defeated **Seleucus Nikator** and gained Afghan territories; **Megasthenes** at his court; ended as a Jain at **Shravanabelagola**.
2. **Bindusara** ("Amitrochates") extended into the Deccan and patronised the **Ajivikas**.
3. **Ashoka (268–232 BCE)** — titles **Devanampiya Piyadassi**.
4. **Sources:** *Arthashastra* (prescriptive, contested date), *Indica* (fragmentary), *Mudrarakshasa* (literary), Buddhist chronicles — and above all **the edicts**.
5. **Administration was UNEVEN:** tight at Pataliputra, delegated to **kumaras** at **Taxila, Ujjain, Suvarnagiri, Tosali**, and loose at the forested edges — control ran along **roads and rivers**, not evenly over territory.
6. **Kalinga war, 261 BCE: 100,000 killed, 150,000 deported**, recorded by Ashoka himself in **Major Rock Edict XIII** — and **deliberately omitted in Kalinga**, where the **Separate Edicts at Dhauili and Jaugada** were installed instead.

7. **Dhamma is NOT Buddhism** — a broad ethical code: respect for elders, for **both** brahmanas and shramanas, kindness to servants, *ahimsa*, generosity, and above all **tolerance (RE XII)**.
8. **Propagated by:** inscriptions, **dhamma mahamattas**, dhamma yattras, public works, and **missions abroad** (Mahinda and Sanghamitta to Sri Lanka; five Hellenistic kings named).
9. **Edicts:** 14 Major Rock Edicts, 7 Major Pillar Edicts, Minor Rock and Pillar Edicts, cave inscriptions. In **Prakrit**, using **Brahmi**, **Kharoshthi** (NW), and **Greek/Aramaic** (Kandahar).
10. **Deciphered by James Prinsep in 1837.** The **Maski** edict identified "Devanampiya Piyadassi" as **Ashoka**.
11. **Mauryan art:** monolithic **Chunar sandstone** pillars with the unreplicated **Mauryan polish**; the **Sarnath Lion Capital** → **State Emblem of India (26 Jan 1950)**, three lions visible, *Satyameva Jayate* from the **Mundaka Upanishad**, Ashoka Chakra on the flag.
12. **Barabar caves** — earliest rock-cut caves, donated to the **Ajivikas**; **Lomas Rishi's** wood-imitating facade.
13. **Decline:** weak successors, over-centralisation (single point of failure), size, finances, provincial misrule (Taxila revolts), foreign pressure. **Brihadratha killed by Pushyamitra Shunga, 185 BCE.**
14. **Assess Ashoka in balance:** genuine ethical transformation *and* an integrative imperial ideology — both readings hold.

Test Yourself

Prelims style

1. Consider the following statements about Ashoka's inscriptions:
 1. They are written mainly in Prakrit.
 2. In the north-west they use the Kharoshthi script.
 3. At Kandahar they appear in Greek and Aramaic. → *All three are correct.*
2. Which Ashokan inscription names the ruler as "Ashoka" rather than by his titles? → *The Minor Rock Edict at Maski (also Gujjarra, Nettur, Udegolam).*
3. Consider the following:
 1. The Barabar caves were donated to the Ajivikas.
 2. They are the earliest surviving rock-cut caves in India.
 3. The Lomas Rishi cave facade imitates a wooden structure. → *All three.*
4. With reference to Ashoka's dhamma, which is/are correct?
 1. It required all subjects to adopt Buddhism.
 2. It enjoined respect for both brahmanas and shramanas.
 3. It was propagated through a special class of officers. → *2 and 3 only. Dhamma was explicitly non-sectarian.*
5. Major Rock Edict XIII is notably absent from — → *Kalinga, where two Separate Rock Edicts were installed instead (Dhauili and Jaugada).*
6. The Lion Capital adopted as India's State Emblem originally stood at — → *Sarnath.*

Mains style

7. Discuss the salient features of Mauryan art and architecture, distinguishing court art from popular art. **(250 words)**
8. "Ashoka's dhamma was as much an instrument of imperial integration as an expression of personal conviction." Critically examine. **(250 words)**

9. Examine the causes of the rapid decline of the Mauryan empire after Ashoka. **(250 words)**
10. **(GS4)** What lessons in ethical leadership can be drawn from Ashoka's response to the Kalinga war? **(150 words)**

Self-check (out loud, no notes):

- Name three sources for Mauryan history and one limitation of each.
- Name the four provincial capitals and who governed them.
- What exactly was dhamma, and how was it *not* Buddhism?
- Why is Rock Edict XIII missing from Kalinga?
- Who deciphered Brahmi, when, and how was Ashoka identified?
- Describe the Sarnath Lion Capital and its links to India's national symbols.
- Give four reasons for Mauryan decline, and say which is structurally strongest.